

IT'S A MATTER
OF LIFE...

Gerry
Hostetler



The sky was the limit for little Derek

This little guy was both gifted and, in a way, hindered. He didn't speak until after he was 2, but he could write the alphabet. He later ran wide-open toward any challenge and nearly always succeeded, said his mom, Linda.

Derek Robert Hagemann died Jan. 28 at Presbyterian Hospital. He was only 8, a third-grader, and died of unusual seizures that still puzzle his doctors, Linda said.

Derek loved wild birds, and in a Friday remembrance ceremony, folks from the Raptor Center released a red-tailed hawk back to the wild.

The center has an injured and unreleasable eagle. Its name? Derek.

Known for his smile

"He came in every day with a huge smile," said Vicki Holocher, his teacher since the first grade at Countryside Montessori School. He so impressed Janine Bryant, another of his



Derek

teachers, that she wrote a poem for the school's yearbook, which will be dedicated in Derek's memory.

"The sky was the limit for Derek," Vicki said. "I had to give him spelling from the middle school list. He was completely self-motivated and was one of the most interesting children I've had the pleasure of teaching in my 20-plus years."

an insatiable curiosity and desire to learn."

He was a teacher, too

Not only did Derek learn, he also taught. He would give a presentation on a subject, then ask and answer questions of his classmates.

Friend Nicole Molinaro said, "When the teacher asked questions, he was always right. Sometimes when he answered math problems, the teacher needed a calculator."

That was true, Vicki said. Teachers did use a calculator to check his answers.

But book learning wasn't Derek's only interest. He held a deputy black belt in tae kwon do and despite his slight build, could break a board with his foot.

Bob, his dad, remembered the 2000 Summer Olympics and how Derek pointed to each athlete's country on a world globe.

"He memorized the countries of the world," Bob said. "We'd ask him to name countries on the western coast of Africa, and he'd rattle them off."

Brother Luke, 10, enjoyed Pokemon and Nintendo with Derek.

Chelsea Fried recalled that Derek liked "Harry Potter" and research. Classmate India Rose Hamilton said Derek was very respectful to everybody.

"When I couldn't get a problem, he helped me and never complained that so many (others) asked him."

Derek was quite the budding artist and easily drew 3-D pictures.

Classmate Connor Roberson said, "He was a really good artist."

Truest friend

One of Derek's closest friends was Joshua Windham.

"He's the truest friend you could ever have," Joshua said. "I thought it was a dream or a nightmare, because this could never happen to a boy like Derek. It's so hard to bear."

Out of the mouths of babes ...

Treasures placed in Derek's casket for the viewing included his black belt and a stuffed eagle.

The black belt is back at home.

The eagle? That's the one Linda hugs to sleep at night.

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Memorials to: Carolina Raptor Center, 6000 Sample Road, Charlotte, NC 28078

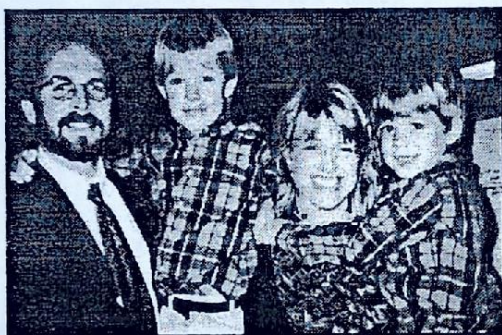
In Memory of Derek

This yearbook is dedicated in loving memory of Derek Hagemann, who touched all who knew him and demonstrated the true essence of a loving spirit. His thirst for knowledge was unending, challenging us all to share in his enthusiasm. Derek's eight inspiring years were filled with interests ranging from archaeology, birds of prey and geology to chess, art and Tae Kwan Do. He was unforgettable to those of us who were privileged enough to have shared in his life, delighting in his wide smile, tender soul and exceptional knowledge.

Countryside Montessori School was given the gift of sharing in Derek's life and his parents were always supportive and truly appreciative of all that the school provided to help guide Derek along his path. We want to thank Linda, Bob and Luke for sharing their gift with us. We will carry Derek's spirit with us forever.

Written by Shari Hatem on behalf of herself and Derek's other teachers, Debbie Summers, Vicki Holocher, Janine Bryant and Allison Kirchmer

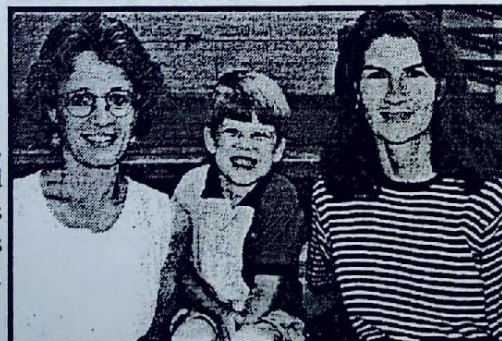
Bob, Luke, Linda and Derek



Luke and Derek demonstrate their Tae Kwan Do skills.



Shari Hatem, Derek and Debbie Summers at The Children's House on the Hill



Derek by Janine Bryant

It's hard to put into words, the feelings in our hearts,
Of why he had to leave us,
Of why he had to part.
Though our thoughts confuse us and leave us in the dark,
We'll try to capture what we feel and how he made his mark.

We'll all think back upon his life with wonderment and tears,
A life filled with awe inspired learning,
Lived fully in eight years.

Instead of looking back with grief, in a sorrow laden lull,
We'll look instead with different eyes
At a sparkling glass half full.

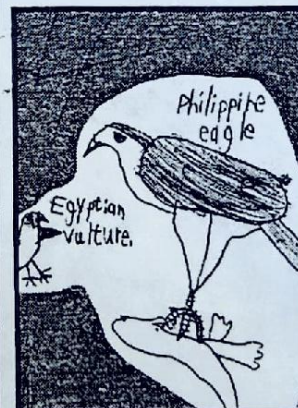
It's true the glass doesn't reach the top,
The way we'd like it to,
But instead of grieving from this loss
Here's what we're going to do.

We'll fill the rest with memories of his time spent here on Earth,
And thank the Lord above, in celebration of his birth.

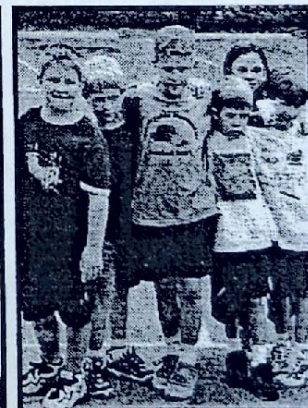
We'll fill it overflowing, with thoughts of happiness and joy,
In honor of the time we shared with this talented, special boy.

So whenever we feel our smiles turning woefully to frowns,
We'll gladly drink from this cup and let our sorrow drown.

For you see,
We are so grateful
For his smiles, laughter and tears.
And we'll rejoice within our hearts,
Because he'll live inside us throughout the years.



Derek loved to draw birds of prey.



Forever Friends
Cameron, Connor, Josh,
Derek and India Rose